

The Claremont City Council held a joint meeting with the School Board on Tuesday, January 30, 2018, in the John Goodrich Room of the Sugar River Valley Regional Technical Center, 111 South Street.

The meeting was called to order by Mayor Lovett at 6:30 p.m.

Members of the Council present were:

At-Large Councilor Claire Lessard
Ward I Councilor Andrew O'Hearne
Ward III Councilor Jonathan Stone
Assistant Mayor Allen Damren
Mayor Charlene Lovett
At-Large Councilor Jeremy Zullo
At-Large Councilor Abigail Kier
At-Large Councilor Nicholas Koloski
Ward II Councilor Scott Pope

Members of the School Board present were:

Alex Herzog
Michael Petrin
Michelle Pierce
Brian Rapp, Chair
Frank Sprague
Rebecca Zullo

Absent:

Chris Irish, Vice Chair

Also present:

Ryan McNutt, City Manager
Dr. Middleton McGoodwin, Superintendent

CITIZEN'S FORUM

None

NEW BUSINESS

Council/School Board Updates

Mr. Rapp said the School Board would meet tomorrow to go over the school budget. February 7, 6:30 p.m., the deliberative session will be held in the Stevens High School auditorium.

Mary Woodman, Claremont School Board Secretary, said the filing deadline for School Board seats is this Friday at 4 p.m. She said that Mr. Benware and she had signed up. Mr. Rapp said four seats will be open.

Mayor Lovett said NHMA gave a presentation on the NH Retirement System at the Council's January 24th meeting. If someone wants the presentation, she can send it to the School Board. She said there will be a second reading and public hearing for the school zone ordinance at the February 14 Council meeting.

Presentation on Proposed Project to Test Household Pets for Lead Poisoning

Dan Kelly, Veterinarian, Lebanon, NH; Mike Van Dolah, Kimball Union Academy (KUA) faculty; and Isabel, KUA student spoke about testing household pets for lead poisoning. Dr. Kelly said a couple of years ago, it was decided to test pets when they arrived at the emergency hospital. One technician's dog tested positive for high blood lead levels. The technician's daughter was also tested and high blood lead levels were found. They were living in Claremont at the time. Now he is working with the students at KUA to try to find a correlation between people and pets with high blood lead levels.

Mr. Van Dolah said the risks to children with lead poisoning is brain damage that is not reversible. Sources of lead exposure include paint and water pipes. Pets can be exposed to lead by chewing on painted wood. Cats can be exposed to paint dust and then ingest it when grooming themselves. Some glazes will have lead. Ideally, they want to see if there is a correlation between pets and their people. Because of HIPAA (Health Insurance Portability and Accountability Act) they are not able to get as much data as they would like, so they are hoping that people will turn out to have their pets tested. If there are correlations in data, families with young children will be made aware of the danger.

Dr. Kelly said this could be a health marker for public health.

Mr. Van Dolah said data collection will be in March. They may coordinate with the Claremont Pet & Aquarium and the Claremont Humane Society. They will advertise the events. They will ask people to fill out questionnaires at the time of their pet's blood draw. It will be anonymous.

Dr. Kelly said SHS students could help with the pet blood drive. They will share the data with the school.

Dr. Kelly said the study from Flint, Michigan, found elevated blood levels. In veterinary medicine, they deal with lead levels when the animal is seizing or is anemic. Not much has been done with low levels. The hope is that this can be presented at public health meetings.

Mayor Lovett said there is a study Dr. Kelly sent her and she will share it with the School Board if anyone is interested.

Mr. Van Dolah said that lead poisoning also affects adults, but not quite as severely as children.

Dr. McGoodwin said the school is very interested in this information. He knows the faculty and student body will be interested in this testing/information.

Dr. Kelly said if the school wants to get involved, students can bring their pets in to be tested.

Mr. McNutt asked if the curriculum developed by KUA can be share with SHS. Mr. Van Dolah said yes.

Ceremonial Signing of SB247

Mayor Lovett said SB247 is the lead bill. This community worked very hard to make positive changes. At the Governor's press conference on January 2nd, he mentioned what Claremont was doing. On February 8, 10 a.m., Governor Sununu will be in Claremont for a ceremonial signing of SB247 at the Common Man Inn. The public is invited to attend.

Mr. Rapp said he is proud of all the work Claremont has done on this. He thanked Mayor Lovett for her leadership on this.

Mr. McNutt said regarding getting the lead out of the water distribution system, in 2015/16 the Water Division began investigating whether water lines had lead in them. Some did. The city spent about \$500,000 to remove approximately 150 lead components. The City is working very closely with the homeowners that are affected (water lines that homeowners are responsible for). He said everything that has been identified will be fixed this year.

Dr. McGoodwin said when the Flint, Michigan, issue hit, a resident was concerned about the water in the school and because of the great records kept by the City, the City was able to allay that concern.

Establishing Community-wide Priorities for 2018

Mayor Lovett's ideas: Changing our online presence – current status negatively impacts Claremont's ability to grow the tax base; securing/stabilizing state funding – very important because we don't have the funding we need; fostering a culture of equality; health – number of community health issues; lastly, economization, combining departments. Doesn't know if it's a good idea, but thinks it is good to exam.

Mayor Lovett said when Marion Lovett gave her presentation, she referenced Niche. On Niche, Claremont schools are rated C minus and the overall rating for the City is a C. If you want to discuss an online presence, you need to determine resources.

Dr. McGoodwin said the information that is available online is what people look at when they are considering relocating here. There is a lack of consistent information about what is going on in our district. He said former City Manager Guy Santagate said one of the Achilles heels in making progress was the perception of the school district. A collaborative plan to provide information about the schools is needed. He talked about the monthly article Mayor Lovett used to write and that people really liked it. A plan needs to be established. An informed public can make informed decisions.

Ms. Kier said Claremont doesn't have a good online presence, but people can go online and write positive reviews on Niche and Google Review.

Mr. Sprague said the "Zillow Effect" comes from the Great Schools website and is based on one data point. Dr. McGoodwin said that using one data point is invalid.

Mayor Lovett said what Claremont has to offer needs to be put out there.

Mr. Pope said sometimes the rating sampling is very small which can skew the results.

Mr. Koloski said it is important to identify these sites and claim ownership. People who are angry will leave comments more often than happy people. There needs to be a policy on how to respond to those reviewers. You need to feed the sites the correct data instead of them posting what they can find. This community has a problem promoting itself. He suggested asking parents to share their positive reviews/experiences online. He said at some point there needs to be a discussion about a shared public information officer.

Mayor Lovett asked if there was a consensus to make this a community-wide priority. If so, then the Council and School Board will ask Mr. McNutt and Dr. McGoodwin to develop a plan to include what resources are needed. Consensus of all.

Mayor Lovett suggested having a presentation from Mr. McNutt and Dr. McGoodwin at the April 17th joint meeting. She noted that this goal may not get done in one year.

Ms. Pierce said regarding mental health, that we need to find more resources. It's an important issue.

Mr. Rapp said mental health is a state issue with not enough funding. He thinks we should look at this.

Ms. Pierce said the Connect Center is a valuable resource.

Mayor Lovett asked what are the issues in the school district with mental health. Dr. McGoodwin said there are serious behavioral issues. Some autistic, adverse childhood experiences, etc. It could have a lifelong impact. The needs of our children in the school district are important, however school resources are limited. The children's needs affect the other students. We are making progress, but there are budget concerns.

Ms. Zullo wants to make sure there are specific goals and that a goal is achieved before moving on to the next subject.

Mr. Pope agreed with Ms. Zullo. Mental health and emotional health issues are not socioeconomic things. Student suicide, auto accidents cross all socioeconomic levels.

Mr. McNutt said there are many different reasons why folks are suffering from these issues. In terms of the City, housing is one of the most sensitive issues in our community. Shelter is a

major need. When you are shelter insecure, it can exacerbate mental health issues. It is important for the City to hold landlords accountable. NICE (Neighborhood Improvement through Code Enforcement) is working to correct situations to make sure people are living in safe housing.

Mr. Koloski talked about poverty and that a lot of these issues link back to housing.

Mr. Petrin talked about a partnership with Brattleboro Retreat and maybe partnering with the City to get funding to get the kids back from other communities.

Dr. McGoodwin said that it has been a four-year journey to find an on-site location for students. Code enforcement to make a building a school requires extensive funds. He will continue to look for an accessible building for children to be educated in Claremont. It costs millions of dollars to transport them to offsite facilities.

Mr. Zullo said it should be the focus of the Council and School Board to find a facility which will lower the school budget and thereby lower the tax rate.

Mr. McNutt said that trying to find a solution to mitigate students leaving the district would create savings. Also, it sounds like retrofitting a structure would be a one-time cost, but the savings would be annually.

Mr. Pope asked for a report of the real costs at the next joint meeting.

Ms. Zullo asked why the Sugar River Valley Regional Technical Center is not the place to do this. Dr. McGoodwin said the vision for this facility is to make it a great draw for the City of Claremont to prepare students for the workforce.

Mayor Lovett asked for figures for the April 17 meeting regarding a facility where you can have day students and also an analysis of what people would be needed to staff that. Ms. Pierce talked about the Brattleboro Retreat people staffing it.

Mayor Lovett said there was a consensus, but we will need a cost analysis. She asked Mr. McNutt if he could bring a list of possible facilities to the next meeting.

Mr. Pope talked about workforce development and needing to leverage grants beyond the Perkins Grant. We need to champion what we have now. He asked how we leverage this to grow our economy. As our workforce is aging, we will need to replace those people. Also, we need high quality workforce housing.

Dr. McGoodwin suggested that this could be a running topic. This tech center will have a major impact on this district/city.

Mr. Pope said that Vermont has started a new campaign to attract residents and they are sending out information as far as California, talking about workforce training and job opportunities.

Mr. McNutt agreed this tech center is vital for Claremont. He talked about the Working Cities Challenge that Corey LeClair, the County Manager and he are working on. If successful, it could mean \$400,000 over three years. He participated in this program in 2013. One requirement is to not just fix one thing, but to create systems for change.

Ms. Kier said to Foster a Culture of Equality, you need to be proactive. She talked about culture week at a former community she lived in.

Mayor Lovett said there is going to be an event in February for Black History Month.

Mayor Lovett talked about the HB413 legislation on the retirement system. She recommended the School Board look at the presentation before the February 7th deliberative session. If HB413 passes, the City could save \$124,000 on an annual basis and the school could save \$217,000 on an annual basis. She'll draft a letter to be sent to all the Representatives and will send it out no later than Monday.

Mayor Lovett said HB525 educational funding adequacy aid is now in the House Finance Committee.

Dr. McGoodwin said the reduction of adequacy aid will add 38 cents per thousand. Mr. Rapp said that is 38 cents every year.

Mayor Lovett said the next joint meeting will be April 17th.

ADJOURNMENT

At 8:33 p.m., a motion was made by Mr. Petrin and seconded by Ms. Pierce to adjourn.

Voice vote: motion carried.

Respectfully Submitted,

Dorée M. Russell
Clerk to the Council